



M I L K B E F O R E M E A T

Within the Lord's Boundaries

How the app honors the Church's guidance on artificial intelligence.

A plain, sourced account of the Church's published counsel on
AI — and exactly how this app was built to stay inside it.

Why this document exists

When a thoughtful member — or a bishop — first hears “an AI app to help share the gospel,” the very first question is the right one: is this allowed?

This document answers that question honestly. It does not claim the app is endorsed, sponsored, or owned by The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. It is not. **Milk Before Meat is an independent, third-party effort, built and run by volunteers.** What this document does is lay the Church’s own published words on artificial intelligence side by side with how the app was built, so anyone can judge for themselves whether it was made in the spirit of that counsel.

Every Church quotation in these pages is taken word-for-word from official sources — the Church Newsroom, the General Handbook, and Elder Gerrit W. Gong’s public teaching. Each is cited on the final page so it can be checked.

A guiding conviction: the way we share this app should follow the same pattern as the app itself — transparent, patient, accountable, and offered under the counsel of those we respect. Where the app reaches past what the Church does internally, this document says so plainly. That honesty is not a weakness in the case. It is the case.

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The Four Guiding Principles

On 13 March 2024, Elder Gerrit W. Gong of the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles and Elder John C. Pingree of the Seventy introduced the Church's guiding principles for its own use of artificial intelligence.

There are four. Read them slowly — the whole of this app was shaped to fit inside them.

1. Spiritual Connection

“The Church will use artificial intelligence to support and not supplant connection between God and His children.”

“The Church will use artificial intelligence in positive, helpful, and uplifting ways that maintain the honesty, integrity, ethics, values, and standards of the Church.”

CHURCH NEWSROOM · GUIDING PRINCIPLES · MARCH 2024

2. Transparency

“People interacting with the Church will understand when they are interfacing with artificial intelligence.”

“The Church will provide attribution for content created with artificial intelligence when the authenticity, accuracy, or authorship of the content could be misunderstood or misleading.”

CHURCH NEWSROOM · GUIDING PRINCIPLES · MARCH 2024

3. Privacy and Security

“The Church's use of artificial intelligence will safeguard sacred and personal information.”

CHURCH NEWSROOM · GUIDING PRINCIPLES · MARCH 2024

4. Accountability

“The Church will use artificial intelligence in a manner consistent with the policies of the Church and all applicable laws.”

“The Church will be measured and deliberate in its use of artificial intelligence by regularly testing and reviewing outputs to help ensure accuracy, truthfulness, and compliance.”

CHURCH NEWSROOM · GUIDING PRINCIPLES · MARCH 2024

Elder Pingree added a line that matters enormously for this project:

“These principles may also be helpful for members and friends of the Church as they navigate a world changing due to AI.”

ELDER JOHN C. PINGREE · MARCH 2024

In other words, the Church offered these principles not only as internal policy, but as counsel members could carry into their own lives. This app takes that invitation seriously.

The General Handbook, 38.8.47

On 16 December 2025, the Church added section 38.8.47, “Appropriate Use of Artificial Intelligence,” to the General Handbook — the standing guidance for the whole Church.

Two sentences sit at its center:

“AI cannot replace the gift of divine inspiration or the individual work required to receive it.”

“Interactions with AI cannot substitute for meaningful relationships with God and others.”

GENERAL HANDBOOK 38.8.47 · DECEMBER 2025

The section then offers practical guidance. Members should use AI in

“positive, helpful, and uplifting ways that uphold the integrity, standards, and teachings of the Church.”

GENERAL HANDBOOK 38.8.47 · DECEMBER 2025

It draws a clear line around sacred preparation —

“AI cannot replace the individual work and spiritual guidance required to prepare divinely inspired talks, lessons, prayers, or blessings,”

GENERAL HANDBOOK 38.8.47 · DECEMBER 2025

— while allowing AI to assist with research, editing, and translation. It counsels members not to rely on AI for “medical, financial, legal, or other sensitive matters,” and warns that sensitive information — Church records, personal member data, confidential communications — should not be entered into AI tools not provided or managed by the Church.

Notice what the Handbook does *not* say. It does not forbid members from using AI to learn, to reflect, or to reach toward God. It draws bright lines around *replacing* revelation, *replacing* relationships, and mishandling *sacred data* — and it asks that AI be used in uplifting ways that honor the Church. Those are precisely the lines this app was designed to respect.

Elder Gong's Teaching

In his video “Faith, Dignity and Human Flourishing: Hearing God’s Voice in an Age of Artificial Intelligence,” Elder Gerrit W. Gong gave the clearest picture of how a disciple should think about this technology.

“Artificial intelligence can answer questions, but it cannot answer prayers. It can organize information, but it cannot offer revelation, covenant connection or divine truth.”

ELDER GERRIT W. GONG

His counsel to members was simple and human:

Let wise use of AI “deepen, not diminish, your relationship with God..., self..., each other..., and natural environment.”

ELDER GERRIT W. GONG · CHURCH NEWSROOM

He taught that AI should “further, not replace, human relationships,” and gave a tender, specific warning: if a person feels tempted to confide more in a chatbot than in a parent, leader, or friend, they should reach out to a real person who knows and loves them. He also noted the Church’s own boundaries — it does not use AI to generate images of Heavenly Father and Jesus Christ, and it will not clone the voices of Church leaders.

If you wanted to write the design brief for this app in a single sentence, you could borrow Elder Gong’s: let the technology *deepen, not diminish*, a person’s relationship with God — and the moment a real human is needed, hand them to one.

Principle by Principle

Here is the app held up against each principle — not in theory, but in the way it was actually built.

Support, not supplant (Spiritual Connection)

HOW THE APP ANSWERS IT

A real human is always one tap away — never buried, never gated. The AI is built to admit uncertainty and to offer a person, not to pose as the final word. Its connection screen says it plainly: “*A real person on our admin team reads every word... this is a person, not a bot.*” The private discipleship space keeps no scores and no streaks; it exists only to help a member notice how Christ is already at work in their life. Nothing in the app tries to be the source of revelation — it tries to walk someone toward the One who is.

People know it is AI (Transparency)

HOW THE APP ANSWERS IT

The conversation is presented as a chat with an AI companion, not a disguised human. When the AI is unsure, it says so, and it offers to pass the question to a real person. The two are kept visibly separate on screen — an AI side and a clearly labeled *Real Person* side — so no one is ever misled about who is answering.

Safeguard sacred and personal information (Privacy & Security)

HOW THE APP ANSWERS IT

The app is local-first: a person’s journey lives on their own device. The Profile shows them *everything* the app has kept about them, with an Edit or Remove control on every single line — removing a line means the app stops using it. A guiding rule of the project is that “a person is not a data point.”

Measured, reviewed, accountable (Accountability)

HOW THE APP ANSWERS IT

In its current phase, every AI response is reviewable by the person running the app, and the entire tester program exists to do exactly what the Church asks of its own AI use: “regularly testing and reviewing outputs to help ensure accuracy, truthfulness, and compliance.” Members test it, a bishop is invited to gather honest feedback, and nothing is rushed to a wider audience until it has been examined.

Don’t replace revelation or relationships (Handbook 38.8.47)

HOW THE APP ANSWERS IT

The app never claims to deliver revelation and never drafts a person’s prayers, talks, blessings, or lessons for them. It points outward — toward scripture the person already trusts, toward real relationships, and ultimately toward real missionaries and the Church itself.

Church principle	In the app
Support, not supplant	A real human always one tap away; AI offers, never poses as final word
People know it is AI	Chat shown as AI; AI/Real-Person kept visibly separate; admits uncertainty
Safeguard information	Local-first; every stored line is editable or removable by the person
Measured & reviewed	Responses reviewable; tester + bishop feedback before any wider rollout
No replacing revelation	Never drafts prayers/talks/blessings; points to scripture and real people
No AI images of Deity / cloned voices	Committed never to generate images of Deity or clone leaders’ voices

Where the App Pushes the Boundary

An honest case names its own hard edges. There are three, and each is the reason the app must remain third-party and volunteer-run for now — not presented as anything the Church has approved.

One — It speaks about faith, not just logistics

THE TENSION

The Church’s internal use of AI leans toward logistics, drafts, translation, and grounded answers from approved sources. This app goes further: it talks with people about God, doubt, and meaning. That is a bigger role for AI than the Church gives it internally.

Why it can still be done in good conscience: the app never claims its words are revelation, never replaces a person’s own spiritual work, and always walks toward a real human and real scripture. It is closer to a thoughtful friend who knows the scriptures than to an oracle. And it is offered for the Church’s review, not in place of it.

Two — It uses a third-party AI model

THE TENSION

The Handbook warns against entering sensitive information into AI tools “not provided or managed by the Church.” This app uses a commercial AI model to generate replies.

How the design respects the spirit of that line: the most sensitive record stays on the person’s own device; the person can see and delete anything stored; and because the project is independent, it is not handling confidential *Church* records at all. As the project grows, formal data-handling commitments and, where appropriate, the counsel of the Church’s own people on data practices should be sought. This is named here, not hidden.

Three — It withholds its full aim until a person is ready

THE TENSION

Following the pattern of milk before meat, the app does not lead with “this is a Latter-day Saint app.” A fair person could ask whether that is fully transparent.

The distinction that matters: the Church’s transparency principle is about people knowing *when they are talking to an AI* — and on that, the app is plain: it is clearly an AI companion that offers a real human. *When* to introduce the restored gospel is a question of missionary *method*, not of AI honesty. The Savior Himself taught in parables, gave milk before meat, and let the rich young ruler walk away. The app is built never to lie about what it is when a person is ready to know — and to honor a “no” completely.

This is exactly why the right path is: build it carefully, let many members test it, invite a bishop to gather honest feedback, document everything against the Church’s own words — and make the call to the Church’s Intellectual Property office before using its name or materials. Slow, transparent, and accountable is not a compromise of the vision. It is the vision.

Our Commitments

These are the standing promises the project makes, so that staying inside the Church's counsel is not a hope but a rule.

- The app will never claim to be sponsored, endorsed, or owned by the Church unless and until the Church says so.
- The app will never generate images of Heavenly Father or Jesus Christ, and will never clone or imitate the voice of any Church leader.
- The AI will never present itself as revelation, and will never draft a person's prayers, blessings, talks, or lessons for them.
- A real human will always be one tap away — never buried, never gated.
- The AI will admit when it is uncertain and offer a real person.
- Every person can see everything the app has stored about them and remove any of it at any time.
- The app will honor a “no” completely; no one is ever pressured, shamed, or routed against their will.
- Outputs will be regularly reviewed for accuracy and truthfulness before the audience widens.
- The project will seek the counsel of priesthood leaders and make the proper call to the Church's Intellectual Property office before using Church name or materials.

“I have fed you with milk, and not with meat: for hitherto ye were not able to bear it.”

1 CORINTHIANS 3:2

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Sources

Every Church quotation in this document can be verified at these official sources.

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